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ESPI Insights

SPACE SECTOR WATCH

ESA awards Galileo and OASIS contracts and expands cooperation with Vast

ESA has extended its existing contracts with Thales Alenia Space and Airbus Defence and Space to add four satellites, bringing the total number of Galileo Second Generation satellites to 16. The extensions, signed on behalf of EUSPA on 23 and 26 October 2026 respectively, are intended to ensure the long-term continuity of the constellation and to support the rollout of new services. On 19 October 2026, **ESA also selected OHB for the feasibility and preliminary design studies of the Outpost for Advanced Scientific Investigation Station (OASIS).** OASIS is a planned shared infrastructure on the lunar surface that will provide power, communications and data storage to multiple scientific and technology payloads over the long term.



Credit: ESA

Concerning human spaceflight, **ESA has signed an MoU with Vast to expand cooperation on post-ISS activities.** The agreement covers cooperation in human spaceflight, science, technology, and commercialisation and follows a phased approach. In the near term, the two organisations intend to focus on astronaut missions and related research on Vast's Haven-1 station and on Vast-PAM-1. The MoU, which formalises this agreement, was signed two days before **ESA astronaut Sophie Adenot returned to Earth with Crew-12 after 237 days aboard the ISS**. The *epsilon* mission exceeded Luca Parmitano's previous European record for a single spaceflight by more than 35 days. She also became the first French woman to conduct an EVA and completed three spacewalks in 14 days.

European Investment Bank and Deutsche Bank launch €560M partnership



Credit: EIB

The European Investment Bank (EIB) and Deutsche Bank have agreed a partnership to support €560M of new investment in European space businesses. The financing will support companies across the space supply chain and target investment in technologies such as reusable launchers and spacecraft, advanced propulsion, satellite manufacturing, and EO. About half of the investment is expected to take place in Germany, with the remainder spread across the European Union. The operation is part of the EIB's Space TechEU initiative, which aims to mobilise approx. €1.4B, and builds on its cooperation with ESA, which provides market intelligence and outreach to connect financing opportunities with eligible companies.

CNES and PLD Space sign agreement to study second launch pad in Kourou



Credit: PLD Space

French Space Agency (CNES) and Spanish PLD Space have agreed to support the development of European launch capabilities of the Guiana Space Centre (GSC). Through the agreement, signed on 1 October 2026, both parties will jointly assess the feasibility of hosting a second launch pad at the ELM-Diamant site to support operations of PLD Space's MIURA 5 and MIURA 9 orbital launchers. Both vehicles are covered by the company's contract with ESA under the European Launcher Challenge, for which ESA committed €158.9M on 27 August 2026. The agreement is intended to support the gradual integration of new European private launchers into the spaceport and to increase its operational capacity and launch cadence.

ASI opens IRIDE services to public bodies and signs Lazio aerospace agreement

The Italian Space Agency (ASI) has opened IRIDE, the national EO constellation, to public administration. The service has been available since 1 October 2026 through the IRIDE Marketplace and comprises 18 geospatial services and 110 products that turn satellite data into tools for land monitoring and management, with eight further IRIDE Eaglet II satellites launched on Transporter-18 on 1 October 2026. **ASI also signed a three-year agreement with the Lazio Region to launch a regional Aerospace and Security Industrial and Technological District,** on 14 October 2026. The agreement aims to strengthen the aerospace supply chain and promote innovation and technology transfer in the district, covering both upstream activities and downstream use of satellite data.

The space agency has also announced that it is exploring a dedicated orbital platform generating artificial gravity for scientific research and technology development. The platform would allow long-term experiments on several research areas, including life sciences at different gravity levels, from microgravity up to the Moon and Mars, hosting small modular experiments.

UK backs £60M debris removal mission and awards LEDA defence contract

The UK Government has committed £60M (approx. €72M) to UK Active Debris Removal (UK ADR), a mission to remove two defunct satellites from LEO by 2032. The refuelable spacecraft, to be launched in 2029 from SaxaVord Spaceport in Scotland, will capture each satellite and release it into a lower orbit where it will burn up in the atmosphere. As part of the mission**, the UK Space Agency has awarded ClearSpace UK a contract to act as the prime contractor,** working with partners across the UK space sector to demonstrate advanced autonomous guidance, navigation and control, and capture technologies able to interact safely with unprepared objects in orbit.



Credit: ClearSpace

On the defence side, **the UK Ministry of Defence has awarded Astroscale UK a contract worth £15M (approx. €18M) for Project LEDA**, a programme to develop and operate spacecraft that help the military understand and counter threats to British satellites. Astroscale UK will lead the project as prime contractor, supported by BAE Systems and Open Cosmos.

Ukraine joins NATO procurement partnership and signs a letter of intent with ICEYE

Ukraine has joined the NATO Support and Procurement Agency (NSPA)'s Security Cooperation Support Partnership, opening NATO contracts to Ukrainian industry. Established in 2025 to provide structured procurement support to Ukraine, the partnership has seven members: Belgium, Luxembourg, Norway, Sweden, the UK, NATO headquarters, and Ukraine, whose accession was announced on 14 October 2026. Following approval by the North Atlantic Council in April 2026, NSPA can now issue solicitations and sign contracts with Ukrainian companies. Later in the week, **the Ministry of Defence of Ukraine also signed a letter of intent with ICEYE and Nokia to explore developing sovereign satellite communications for Ukraine**. The letter follows a partnership concluded by the two companies in October 2026 to jointly develop broadband LEO satellite communications systems for governments, giving nations ownership and control of the satellites, ground segment and terminals.

JAXA successfully launches Martian Moons eXploration (MMX) mission

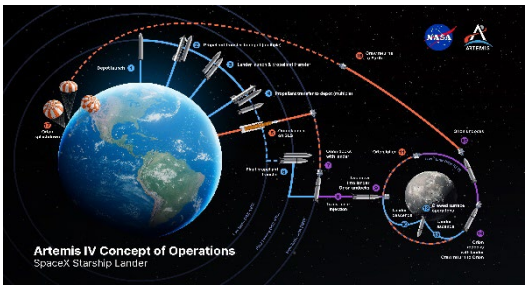


Credit: DLR

On 20 October 2026, **JAXA successfully launched the Martian Moons eXploration (MMX) mission to study Mars' only two moons, Phobos and Deimos.** The five-year mission lifted off from the Tanegashima Space Center on an H3 rocket and is expected to reach the martian system in one year. The spacecraft aims to collect at least 10g of material from Phobos's surface and return it to Earth in 2031, which would be the first sample return mission from the martian system. The analysis of these samples aims to determine the origin of the two moons. **The spacecraft also carries Idefix, a rover developed by CNES and the German Aerospace Center (DLR),** which is due to land on Phobos around the turn of 2028/2029 and operate for about 100 days.

NASA redefines Artemis III and awards $38M contract for lunar 5G network

NASA has redefined Artemis III as a rendezvous and docking test in LEO between the Orion spacecraft and test versions of the Blue Origin and SpaceX landers, planned for 2027, presenting the new approach at its "Artemis Acceleration" event on 23 October 2026. Each company must complete an uncrewed demonstration and obtain NASA certification before any crewed landing, and the provider for the first crewed landing, planned for 2028, will be selected depending on lander readiness.



Credit: NASA

NASA has also awarded Modulate Space a $38M contract to develop key elements of a 5G communications system with built-in Wi-Fi 6 for the lunar surface. The contract is managed by NASA's Glenn Research Center and runs from 30 November 2026 to 31 December 2028. Furthermore, **NASA has reported progress on its Moon Base rovers:** Astrolab and Lunar Outpost, which each hold a task order for a crewed lunar terrain vehicle, are on schedule to deliver flight-ready hardware at the end of 2027, and Blue Origin is due to deliver the vehicles to the lunar south pole by 2028.

Kenya signs funding agreement and appoints advisers for commercial spaceport

The Kenya Space Agency has signed a funding agreement with the Public Private Partnerships Directorate of Kenya's National Treasury to onboard a transaction advisor and start detailed planning of a commercial spaceport project on the country's coast. On 27 October 2026**, a consortium led by Salience Consulting, a management advisory firm specialising in digital infrastructure, was appointed to provide these advisory services for a site in Kipini, in Tana River County.** Salience Consulting is responsible for the financial, legal, environmental, and social work. Among its partners, spaceport architecture company SpaceDreamS will lead technical feasibility and systems engineering, while consulting engineering company Gauff Consultants Africa will cover civil and infrastructure engineering. The feasibility study will assess sites, launch infrastructure, market demand and economic viability, as well as options for private-sector participation. If the project goes ahead, the consortium is expected to support the public-private partnership through to financial close.

IN OTHER NEWS

ESA Council appoints two new directors

On 22 October 2026, ESA Council approved the appointment of Andrzej Banasiak as Director of Commercialisation and Industry Partnership and of Nicolaus Hanowski as Director of Space Operations. Both will take up their posts on 1 January 2027.

European Commission extends SALTO deadline to end of 2026

The European Commission has extended the deadline for the SALTO reusable launcher project to the end of 2026, giving it three more months to complete the first hop test of the Themis demonstrator. SALTO is an ArianeGroup-led EU research project worth €42.8M, built on the ESA-managed Themis programme.

Norway proposes about €60M for Andøya launch pad

Norway has proposed NOK 646M (approx. €60M) to fund a second orbital launch pad at Andøya Spaceport. The 2027 budget proposal allocates an initial NOK 323.3M (approx. €31M), with the remainder due in 2028. The state will own the pad and will lease it to Andøya Space. Completion is targeted for 2028, pending parliamentary approval.

Mauritius unveils its Space Strategy 2036

On 5 October 2026, the Mauritius Research and Innovation Council (MRIC) unveiled the country's Space Strategy 2036. The strategy sets four priorities: developing national expertise in space science and technology, increasing the use of satellite data, promoting collaborative research, particularly in the blue economy, and expanding partnerships with international space organisations.

Uzbekistan and Vietnam sign Artemis Accords

Uzbekistan and Vietnam joined the Artemis Accords on 19 and 28 October 2026 respectively, bringing the total number of signatories to 78.

Turkish and South African space agencies sign MoU

On 10 October 2026, South African National Space Agency (SANSA) signed an MoU with the Turkish Space Agency to set out a framework for cooperation on shared priorities in space science and exploration without yet specifying projects or timelines.

ispace signs lunar agreements with Leonardo, Telespazio, ArianeGroup and ALTEC

ispace has signed an MoU with Leonardo and Telespazio to explore cooperation on lunar communications, PNT infrastructure and services, as well as lunar transportation. The agreement builds on a 2025 letter of intent between ispace and Telespazio and extends the cooperation to Leonardo's capabilities in space robotics and AI. The parties will also assess transporting satellites for ESA's Moonlight programme, led by Telespazio, to lunar orbit aboard ispace's orbital transfer vehicle.



Credits: ispace

On the same day, **ispace signed another MoU with ArianeGroup to expand their cooperation beyond the ULTRA lunar lander.** ArianeGroup already supplies pulsing and reaction control system thrusters for ULTRA, together with assembly, integration and testing (AIT) services. The two companies will also evaluate long-term commercial agreements to support stable lander production. Finally, **ispace-EUROPE has signed an MoU with ALTEC**, the Turin-based company owned by Thales Alenia Space and the Italian Space Agency (ASI). The MoU covers the use of ALTEC's facilities for lunar rover testing, mission simulations and operator training, including a new Lunar Simulation Centre funded by ASI.

European and US mobile operators join forces on satellite direct-to-device

Deutsche Telekom, Orange, Telefónica and Vodafone have signed a letter of intent to explore a joint bid for future Mobile Satellite Services (MSS) spectrum in Europe, with the aim of offering D2D services. The spectrum concerned is in the 2 GHz band, **which the European Commission is due to allocate in 2027**. Under the planned model, the four operators would build ground network infrastructure and coordination and monitoring functions in Europe without investing directly in a constellation, which would come from a satellite partner still to be selected. All mobile network operators would receive open and non-discriminatory access to offer D2D services, and the four operators' existing satellite partnerships would remain in place.

On the other side of the Atlantic, **AT&T, T-Mobile and Verizon formally established their D2D joint venture** on 1 October 2026, following the agreement in principle reached in May. The joint venture will pool the carriers' spectrum to close coverage gaps, work with rural operators and promote a standards-based approach to device compatibility. **The carriers' existing agreements also remain in place**: T-Mobile with SpaceX, AT&T with AST SpaceMobile, and Verizon with Skylo and AST SpaceMobile. More on what this means for Europe in ESPI's latest brief, ***Borrowed Bandwidth? Direct-to-device and Europe's ambition for full-stack autonomy***.

Skyroot partners with Brazil's Concert and wins two Reflect Orbital launches

Indian Skyroot Aerospace has signed an MoU with Brazil's Concert Technologies to jointly develop a new launch vehicle capable of placing more than 100 kg into LEO. The two-year agreement was signed on 7 October 2026 at the International Astronautical Congress (IAC) in Antalya. It combines technologies from the Brazilian Micro-Launcher (MLBR) programme, of which Concert Technologies is a member, with Skyroot's Vikram family. **The new vehicle is intended to fill the gap** between the MLBR launcher, designed for payloads of up to 40 kg, and the larger Vikram rockets. **Skyroot has also signed a contract with US company Reflect Orbital for two dedicated launches** to deploy spacecraft for its planned constellation of orbital mirrors, which is designed to redirect sunlight to specific locations on Earth. The first mission will fly on Vikram-1, which reached orbit on its maiden flight in July 2026, and the second on the Vikram-1U variant currently in development. No launch dates were disclosed.

Airbus completes first 32 new OneWeb satellites as Eutelsat expands services

Airbus Defence and Space has completed the first 32 new OneWeb LEO satellites for Eutelsat at its facility in Toulouse, following the relocation of OneWeb series production to Europe. The satellites are now being prepared for shipment ahead of a launch with SpaceX. They are the first of the 669 new OneWeb satellites Eutelsat has ordered to progressively replace those reaching the end of their operational lives.

On 14 October 2026, **Eutelsat also renewed its multi-transponder, multi-year agreement with Antik Telecom and A1**. Under the agreement, Eutelsat will provide capacity at its 16° East orbital position for DTH television services in Slovakia and Czechia, while A1 provides headend hosting and uplink services for the Antik Sat platform. **Eutelsat also expanded its capacity agreement with EuroSkyPark**, a German provider of secure communications for critical infrastructure, to support Amprion, one of Germany's largest electricity transmission system operators. Using GEO capacity on the Eutelsat 10B satellite, the expanded agreement will extend connectivity from Amprion's onshore substations to its North Sea offshore infrastructure, independently of terrestrial networks.

In Africa, **Paratus Namibia launched Eutelsat's OneWeb LEO service** for residential and business customers across the country. The launch falls under the multi-year agreement the two companies signed in November 2025 covering five Southern African countries.

ICEYE partners with OroraTech on wildfires and launches two satellites for Portugal



Credits: ICEYE

ICEYE has partnered with Munich-based OroraTech, which operates a commercial thermal infrared satellite constellation, **to integrate OroraTech's thermal data with ICEYE's SAR observations in a single wildfire intelligence service**. OroraTech's data extend it to the earliest stages of an event, detecting initial hotspots and tracking the fire front as it develops, while ICEYE's SAR satellites observe through smoke, cloud and darkness to assess impacts on structures and infrastructure while the fire is still underway. The joint service is aimed at governments and emergency managers, utilities and insurers, with uses ranging from pre-positioning resources and planning evacuations to assessing threats to power grids and triaging insurance claims.

On 20 October 2026, **ICEYE also launched four new SAR satellites aboard SpaceX's Bandwagon-5 rideshare mission**, including two for Portugal's Atlantic Constellation procured by CTI Aeroespacial.

PLD Space begins MIURA 5 system-level testing with three vehicles built

Spanish PLD Space has begun system-level testing of its MIURA 5 orbital launcher after manufacturing its first three vehicles. Two of them are qualification units for different test campaigns, and the third is the first flight vehicle, which is still being integrated. The campaign centres on a fully integrated second stage, combining structures, avionics, feed system, control systems and propulsion. It is now installed vertically at the company's Teruel test facility for a wet dress rehearsal and a static hot-fire test ahead of the first demonstration flight, planned for the first half of 2027. PLD Space has also completed stage-separation tests and the test campaigns for both qualification models of the fairing. To date, the company has built seven complete engines and 13 tanks, and has flight avionics available for four complete rockets.

Beyond Gravity doubles dispenser capacity in Sweden and supplies OneWeb panels

Beyond Gravity has expanded its satellite dispenser production site in Linköping, Sweden, doubling capacity from 96 to 192 dispenser modules per year as of October 2026, or around 48 launches depending on configuration. The expansion adds a hall of approximately 2,500 m², bringing the site's production area to around 15,000 m², together with a new high-precision milling machine for carbon fibre and aluminium components. The main driver is Amazon Leo, for which Beyond Gravity has been the exclusive dispenser provider since 2022. All 396 Amazon Leo satellites deployed so far have used dispensers from Linköping, across launchers from Arianespace, ULA, Blue Origin and SpaceX, and the added capacity will also allow the site to serve further constellation customers.

Beyond Gravity has also delivered structural panels for the 32 new Eutelsat OneWeb satellites now being prepared for launch at Airbus in Toulouse.

Rocket Lab delays Neutron to 2027 and flies 98th Electron mission



Credits: Rocket Lab

Rocket Lab has postponed the inaugural launch of its Neutron medium-lift rocket to 2027 without setting a specific date, having previously targeted the fourth quarter of 2026. **In a presentation accompanying the announcement, CEO Peter Beck explained** that inspections had found voids in the carbon-composite forward dome of the first-stage propellant tank. The company expects to share a new target date once the replacement structures have been completed and qualified. Nonetheless, on 23 October 2026, **Rocket Lab launched its 98th Electron mission** from Launch Complex 1 in New Zealand, deploying three radio-frequency-sensing satellites for HawkEye 360 in LEO. It was the company's 19th launch of the year and its third dedicated Electron mission for HawkEye 360.

A Rocket Lab-built spacecraft also reached orbit on 20 October: **Maxwell, which Viasat will use for demonstrations under NASA's Communications Services Project**, launched on SpaceX's Bandwagon-5 rideshare mission to test high- and low-rate relay services for spacecraft in LEO.

SpaceX buys low-band spectrum for Starlink Mobile and expands airline deals

SpaceX has agreed to acquire Grain Management's nationwide 800 MHz spectrum portfolio, covering up to 14 MHz of paired low-band spectrum, to support its Starlink Mobile D2D service. The deal is reportedly worth approx. $8 billion and remains subject to approval by the Federal Communications Commission (FCC). SpaceX plans to use the band, which improves indoor coverage, alongside the 2 GHz spectrum it already holds in a hybrid satellite-terrestrial network.

Starlink Mobile also expanded internationally, as **Banglalink launched the service in Bangladesh**, allowing customers with compatible 4G phones to message and share their location in areas without terrestrial coverage. In aviation, **American Airlines extended its Starlink agreement** on 8 October 2026 to cover its entire mainline fleet of more than 1,030 Airbus and Boeing aircraft, with installations starting in early 2027. **easyJet also selected Starlink** to introduce onboard Wi-Fi for the first time across its Airbus fleet, with installations starting in the first half of 2027 and completion expected by early 2028.

IN OTHER NEWS

Avio USA and Lockheed Martin sign rocket motor agreement

On 13 October 2026, Avio USA and Lockheed Martin signed a strategic cooperation agreement for solid rocket motors for the Extended-Range Guided Multiple Launch Rocket System and the Precision Strike Missile. Production will take place at Avio USA's new facility in Hurt, Virginia, once the motors are qualified.

The Exploration Company to test ONEIROS lunar hopper in 2027

The Exploration Company plans to test ONEIROS, an approx. one-tonne lunar hopper demonstrator powered by a throttleable methane engine, in the United Arab Emirates in 2027. The privately funded project, covered by an MoU with the UAE Space Agency, will validate autonomous navigation and hazard avoidance.

SES selects Lyntris for US Space Force satellite payload

SES has selected Lyntris to supply the radio-frequency payload, including antennas and pointing systems, for the first two satellites it is building under the US Space Force's Protected Tactical SATCOM-Global programme. Initial operational capability is targeted for fiscal year 2029.

Rocket Factory Augsburg appoints Alexander Dahm as CEO

On 5 October 2026, Rocket Factory Augsburg named Alexander Dahm, formerly Chief Operating Officer of HENSOLDT Sensors, as its new Chief Executive Officer. He succeeds Indulis Kalnins and will lead the company towards the maiden flight of RFA ONE.

Astrolight demonstrates space-to-ground laser links

Lithuanian company Astrolight has established 1 Gbps laser links between its ATLAS-1 terminal on the ERMIS-3 nanosatellite and the OGS-2.5 optical ground station in Greece. Developed with ESA, the system became routine within a week and is designed for data rates of up to 10 Gbps.

SSC Space signs agreements with two Japanese companies

On 14 October 2026, as it launched its Japanese subsidiary, SSC Space signed an MoU with ElevationSpace covering microgravity research, launch, reentry and recovery, and ground station services.

Amazon Leo receives regulatory approval for $11.5B Globalstar deal

The US Federal Communications Commission (FCC) has approved Amazon Leo's planned $11.5B acquisition of satellite operator Globalstar, concluding its regulatory review of the transaction. The approval covers the transfer of approx. 25 MHz of mobile satellite service spectrum, which Amazon plans to use alongside Globalstar's infrastructure to expand its satellite connectivity services and strengthen its direct connectivity capabilities for mobile devices. Following completion of the acquisition, Amazon Leo may also use Globalstar's recently authorised C3 system, comprising 48 satellites, to develop additional mobile satellite services. The transaction is also expected to support emergency communications and additional satellite data services.

Czech defence group CSG acquires strategic stake in MDA Space

Czech industrial and defence group CSG has acquired a 9.5% stake in Canadian space company MDA Space, becoming its largest shareholder. The investment is part of CSG's strategy to expand its presence in the space sector. **The stake was estimated to be worth approx. $434M** based on MDA Space's share price, although the transaction price was not disclosed. MDA Space operates across satellite systems and geointelligence, serving commercial and government markets. The companies may explore joint investments in manufacturing and assembly facilities in Europe and opportunities for international commercial expansion.

Xona secures $250M Series D to scale Pulsar constellation

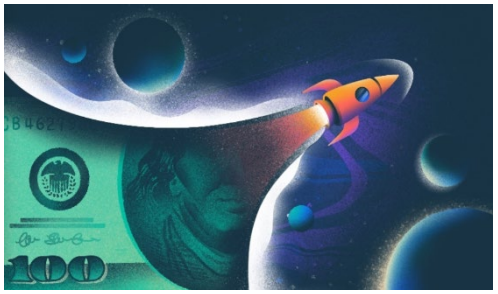
US satellite navigation company Xona Space Systems has raised $250M in a Series D round led by Future Ventures, reaching a valuation of $2.45B and bringing its total funding to over $570M. The investment will support the expansion of satellite manufacturing capacity, further deployment of its Pulsar constellation and development of its global navigation service. Xona recently launched six Pulsar satellites, four of which are expected to begin providing services to customers in 2027. The remaining two are the first spacecraft entirely designed and manufactured at the company's facility in California.



Credit: Xona

Astranis obtains $468M credit facility for GEO satellite production

US satellite manufacturer Astranis has received approval for a $468M credit facility from the Export-Import Bank of the United States (EXIM) to expand domestic spacecraft production. The financing was approved under EXIM's Make More in America Initiative, with J.P. Morgan acting as sole arranger and structuring agent. The facility will support increased manufacturing capacity and the launch of additional satellites to serve commercial and government customers worldwide. Astranis operates a satellite manufacturing plant in Northern California and has already launched five spacecraft. The company reports more than $1.2B in commercial contracts, with the financing intended to support existing orders and further international expansion.



Credit: Astranis

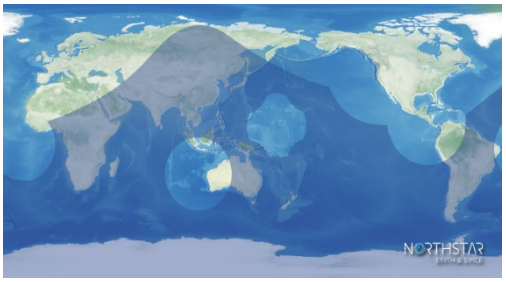
Stoke Space receives conditional $150M loan commitment from Department of War

US launch company Stoke Space has signed a conditional $150M loan commitment with the US Department of War's Office of Strategic Capital (OSC) to expand its launch infrastructure at Cape Canaveral Space Force Station. While the company's existing launch infrastructure supports its Nova Pathfinder medium-lift rocket, the new facility would accommodate the larger Nova Block 2 vehicle, currently under development. The expansion aims to increase launch capacity for commercial and national security missions. The loan remains subject to financial, legal, technical and due diligence requirements before it can be finalised.

Firehawk Defense secures over $150M to expand rocket motor production

Firehawk Defense has raised more than $150M in an oversubscribed Series D financing round led by Advent International and Rochefort Asset Management, reaching a valuation of more than $1.4B. The funding will support the expansion of the company's propellant production facility in Lawton, Oklahoma, and its missile integration facility in Crawford, Mississippi. Firehawk Defense aims to scale production processes to address demand for tactical propulsion and munitions from US and allied defence customers.

NorthStar Earth & Space goes public through SPAC merger with Viking



Credit: NorthStar Earth & Space

Canadian space company NorthStar Earth & Space has completed its merger with Viking Acquisition Corp. I, and its shares began trading on NYSE American on 2 October 2026. NorthStar Earth & Space raised $30M through a private investment in public equity (PIPE) round anchored by Cartesian Capital Group, alongside its special-purpose acquisition company (SPAC) merger with Viking Acquisition Corp. I. The transaction was accompanied by significant investor redemptions, with holders of more than 96% of the SPAC's public shares electing to redeem their investments. Viking's trust account had held approximately $230M as of December 2025. The transaction reportedly generated **an estimated $25M in net proceeds**, to be used to support the deployment of its orbital sensor constellation and the expansion of its SSA and SDA services. Headquartered in Montreal, Canada, with a European headquarters in Luxembourg, NorthStar provides orbital monitoring services to government and commercial customers.

EQT completes acquisition of German satellite deployment company Exolaunch

German company Exolaunch has completed its acquisition by EQT X, a fund managed by Swedish investment group EQT, following an agreement announced in June 2026. The transaction's financial terms were not disclosed. The new ownership will support the expansion of Exolaunch's global operations, further investment in satellite deployment technologies and the development of additional services across the space sector. The company recently secured launch capacity aboard Japan's H3 rocket for 2027 and was selected as launch integrator for the German Space Agency and NASA's GRACE-C mission, planned for 2028. Exolaunch is also expanding into payload return services through a contract for SpaceX's Starfall mission, scheduled no earlier than 2029.

IN OTHER NEWS

Argotec closes €50M funding round to scale satellite production

Italian satellite manufacturer Argotec has closed a €50M funding round subscribed by NUO Space, an investment vehicle backed by Italian holding company NUO. The investment will support the expansion of its manufacturing capabilities in Italy and the US.

Fortastra secures $30M Series A for orbital security

US spacecraft developer Fortastra has closed a $30M Series A round led by First In, with participation from Upfront Ventures, Space Capital and other investors. The investment will fund the construction of manoeuvrable spacecraft prototypes and support manufacturing capabilities.

Kapta Space raises $24M to expand radar payload production

US company Kapta Space has raised $24M in a Series A round led by Washington Harbour Partners and co-led by Bison Ventures, bringing its total funding to $30M. The investment will support the expansion of radar payload manufacturing and the further development of its technology.

Seraphim Space Investment Trust invests $23.1M in Skylo

Seraphim Space Investment Trust has invested an additional $23.1M in Skylo Technologies, an existing portfolio company backed since 2023. The company develops satellite connectivity technologies that extend mobile network coverage beyond the reach of terrestrial infrastructure.

Rendezvous Robotics raises $20M for orbital assembly

Rendezvous Robotics has raised $20M in a seed round led by MaC Venture Capital and Toyota Ventures. The funding will support the development of modular spacecraft, with a demonstration involving seven modules planned for 2028.

Australia’s MP Space closes about €13.8M seed round

MP Space has raised AU$23M (approx. €13.8M) in a seed round led by Blackbird, with participation from Seraphim Space and other international investors. The capital will be used to expand manufacturing capacity and develop new power systems for spacecraft.

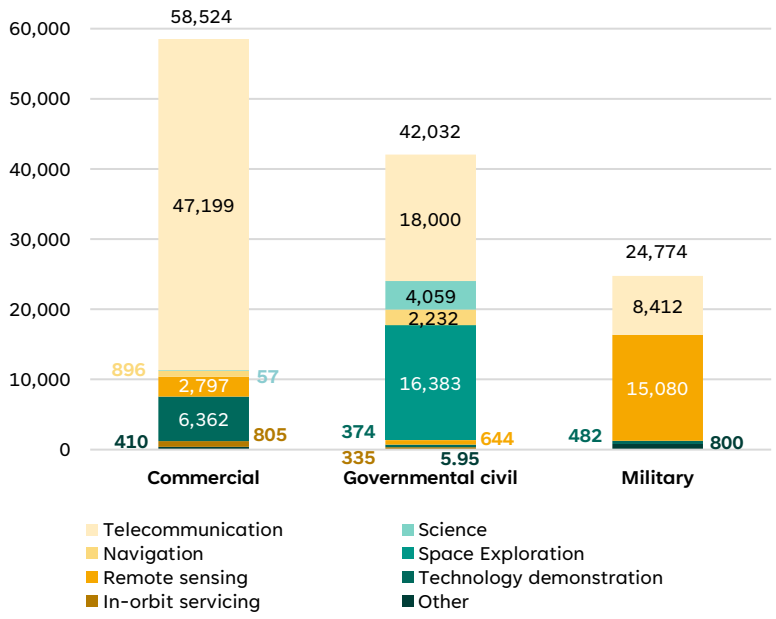
LAUNCHES & PAYLOAD – SEPTEMBER 2026

Launch provider's region	USA	China	Europe	Russia	India	Japan	New Zealand	Others	Total
Number of launches	10	6	0	0	1	1	1	1	**20**
Number of spacecraft launched	268	36	0	0	1	2	3	15	**325**
Mass launched (in t)	96	22	0	0	2	4	0.1	0.5	**125**

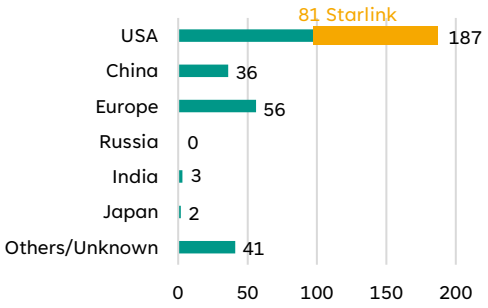
Top launch service providers of the month

1. SpaceX (10)
2. CASC (4)
3. ISRO, JAXA (1)

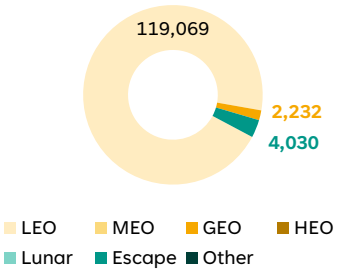
Mass launched (in kg) by market and by mission

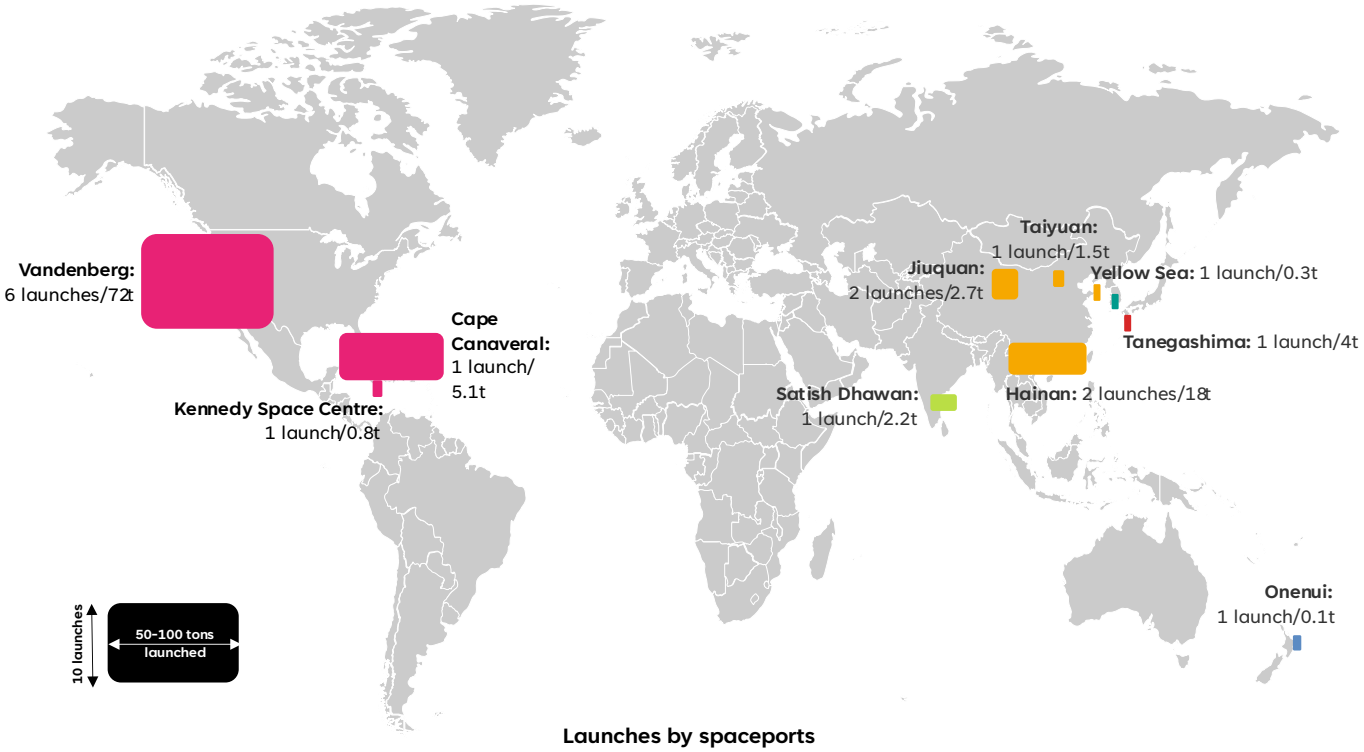


Number of spacecraft launched by payload owner's region



Mass launched (in kg) by orbit





Launches by spaceports

*The data is an estimation from ESPI's internal launches dataset, publicly accessible through the **ESPI Launch Dashboard**.*

ESPI
Insights

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LAUNCHES & PAYLOADS

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